

Cysic's Venus could reduce ZK-rollup costs

Cysic has released Venus as open source code, unveiling a hardware-optimised proving backend for the open source Zisk zkVM that could significantly reduce zero-knowledge rollup costs and make ZK-based Ethereum layer-2 networks price-competitive with optimistic rollups.

The release directly addresses the long-standing cost disadvantage that has kept ZK-rollups more expensive despite their stronger cryptographic guarantees and instant finality. Built on top of Zisk, now independently stewarded by SilentSig Switzerland GmbH, Venus replaces the earlier CPU-first opaque proving pipeline with a visible, composable computational graph that enables global optimisation across proof-generation workflows.

Key upgrades include native CUDA Graph integration, a full FPGA backend, and a preliminary ASIC design path, extending acceleration beyond CPUs into purpose-built hardware. Early benchmarks show measurable throughput gains on an RTX 5090 over the Zisk baseline.

Released under Apache 2.0/MIT dual licensing, Venus is positioned as an ecosystem-wide open source contribution, with community testing and downstream development actively encouraged.

"ZK-rollups have always been the superior scaling solution – except for cost. Venus is our contribution to closing that gap," said Leo Fan, founder, Cysic.

The code has not yet been audited for production use, but if widely adopted, Venus could remove the economic premium long associated with secure ZK scaling.

reportedly had a background in SEO, crypto, and online marketing. The backdoor was inserted post-acquisition.

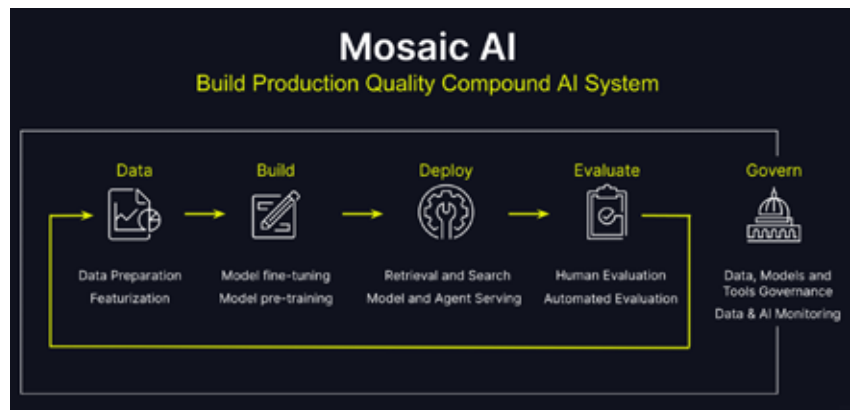
This marks the second plugin hijack in weeks, signalling a growing trend of weaponising open source trust. Affected plugins have been permanently removed, with users urged to uninstall them immediately and audit their systems.

The incident underscores the urgent need for stronger governance, transparency, and post-acquisition code audits across open source ecosystems.

Ridge AI raises \$2.6M in pre-seed round

Open source Mosaic is at the core of Ridge AI's stealth exit and \$2.6 million pre-seed round, positioning the startup at the intersection of browser-native analytics, AI agents, and B2B SaaS infrastructure.

The round was led by Madrona, with participation from TheFounderVC and angels including founding leaders from Tableau, Trifacta, and Streamlit. The company is commercialising Mosaic, the open source interaction framework, alongside DuckDB and WebAssembly, to let software providers deploy interactive customer-facing dashboards and AI data agents in hours instead of months.



The platform's key differentiator lies in browser-native processing, which delivers sub-second interactivity across million-row datasets while eliminating recurring per-query cloud infrastructure costs. Embedded dashboards also support natural-language follow-up questions through Ridge's AI data agent, enabling immediate customer insights inside SaaS products.

The open source credibility of the company is reinforced by chief scientist and co-founder Jeff Heer, a University of Washington professor and co-director of the UW Interactive Data Lab, known for helping create D3.js, Vega, and Mosaic. His research in browser-native analytics and interactive visualisation forms the technical foundation of the company's product.

CEO and co-founder Ellie Fields, formerly a Tableau executive and chief product and engineering officer at Salesloft, said product teams often lost months proving customer value through custom dashboards instead of building core differentiation.

The timing reflects a wider convergence of LLMs for data reasoning, WebAssembly browser compute, and open source visualisation frameworks, creating a strong new category where AI agents meet open source embedded analytics infrastructure.

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